SUNY Old Westbury 2026-2027 Undergraduate Catalog

Course Descriptions

Contract All Courses |

Performing Arts

MD 1000 - Music of Global Cultures I

Credits: 4

An introductory course focused on understanding and exploring the meaning and art of traditional and popular music and global cultures. This course presents music from diverse cultures examining historical perspectives and their impact on society. Students will be introduced to basic rhythms, melodies and harmonies. Cultures on focus include introduction to the music of Africa, Europe, Asia and the Americas. Course will include review of videos, films and recordings, and may include one field trip outside of regular class time to attend a live concert.

MD 1010 - Music of Global Cultures II-An Interactive Course

Credits: 4

The course will focus on the relationship of music to the cultural and social environments of diverse communities. Music will be examined as a rhythmic newspaper creatively expressing the voice of culturally diverse communities seeking to inform and contribute to the mosaic of civil society. Working with professional musicians, students will be introduced to music theory, basic reading, writing and composition. Cultures on focus include expanded introduction to the music of Africa, Asia, Europe and the Americas. Course will include review of videos, films and recordings.

MD 1100 - Traditional and Popular Dances of Global Cultures

Credits: 4

This introductory dance course bridges the disciplines of music, song and dance, exploring the ways in which tradition and popular dances transmit meaning and contribute to an understanding of cultural diversity. The basic dance course

focuses on healthy alignment principles that strengthen the body. The course will emphasize the dance techniques of diverse societies of Africa, Europe and the Americas. Cultures on focus include introduction to the music of Africa, Europe, Asia and the Americas. Course will include review of videos, films and slides.

MD 1110 - The Culturally Diverse Language of Dance-The Anatomy of Movement

Credits: 4

Dance embodies the language of culture through movement. This introductory course examines the role of dance in articulating the human rights of diverse cultural communities. The historical global dance survey will focus on the societal conditions that created and influenced different dance styles and movements. Working with professional dancers and musicians, students will study dance history, improvisation and basic dance composition. The interactive dance survey will include the cultures of Africa, Asia, Europe and the Americas. Course will include review of videos, films and slides.

MD 1111 - Dance Ensemble

Credits: 1

The Dance Ensemble involves the development of proficiency in dance performance through rehearsal and presentation of various forms of dance. If interested, participants in the Dance Ensemble will also have a chance to create some of their own choreography for the semester concert. A concert is presented on-campus each semester. Admission is by permission of instructor following audition. All levels of dance experience encouraged to apply.

Prerequisites

Permission of Instructor**Corequisite** None**Prerequisite/Corequisite**

Permission of Instructor

When Offered:

Every Semester

MD 2350 - Acting I

Credits: 4

This course will introduce acting as an intellectually academic, emotional, and physical art giving each its due. The course's approach to acting is largely based on the Stanislavsky method of actor training known as the "Magic If": "What would I do IF … I were that character in that situation." We will work to achieve that reality through theater games and improvisations and by working on scenes cast with two or three actors from classic or contemporary full length or one act plays The scenes will be selected to be appropriate for the mostly young adult student body. Students will analyze their own and other students' performances through class discussions and in written assignments. The class will culminate in a performance of the scenes during the assigned final exam week.

When Offered:

Every semester.

MD 2633 - Introduction to Music Composition

Credits: 4

In this introductory course in music, students explore the language of music through successive readings, research projects, listening, and compositional assignments. A study of a wide diversity of musical styles serves as an incentive for student compositions in those styles. Students will examine a variety of topics, such as history and theory of music, orchestration, form, and aesthetic considerations of music genres and idioms. Drawing from a broad range of musical styles, traditions, and historical periods student will produce 5 short pieces and 2 research projects based on class discussions and assigned readings. Background in music not required.

MD 3010 - History of Jazz

Credits: 4

Jazz is a unique American art form and an integral part of the American experience. This class will study the evolution of jazz, starting with its roots in work songs, spirituals, and the Blues songs of African slaves and African- Americans and continuing with the influence of European music on these to create the jazz forms of the New World. The course covers the birth of jazz in New Orleans and its dissemination to St. Louis, Chicago, Kansas City and New York. There will be a review of the great innovators and popularizers and investigation of its forms and structures.

When Offered:

Periodically.

MD 3110 - Modern Dance

Credits: 4

This course is focused on the techniques and elements of modern dance. Classroom exercises and materials will be informed by historical pioneers of modern dance as well as more contemporary choreographers and practitioners. Exercises will build strength, flexibility, and stamina, as well as sharpen the student's awareness of body, movement and physical environment. Particular attention will be paid to: elements of fall and recovery from Limon technique, concepts from Graham technique such as contract and release, and basics of Horton Technique such as flatback and lateral movement. Somatic approaches will be called upon to enrich the experience of conscious embodiment

Prerequisites

MD 1110 or equivalent or Instructor Permission

When Offered:

Every other semester

MD 3350 - Acting II

Credits: 4

This course will on the continued development of the actor's imagination and an exploration of their inner resources as they relate to the external demands and skills of the craft. These principles will then be applied rigorously in rehearsal and performance of classical, contemporary and original performance pieces created by the students themselves. We will delve deeper into the creation of a character, script analysis, and explore long form improvisation. The course will also explore concepts of screen performance and related conventions of film production through lectures, discussions, introductions, demonstrations, readings and screenings. Students will not only learn how to act, they will develop the ability to direct and objectively critique their classmates.

Prerequisites

MD 2350 or equivalent or Instructor Permission

When Offered:

Every other semester

Visual Arts

MD 1112 - Music Ensemble

Credits: 1

Music Ensemble allows for students to work with the Professor to create their own, planned, music ensemble for a performance at end of semester. A concert is presented on-campus each semester. Admission is by instructor for planning of the ensemble. Music Ensemble has the option of credit/no credit. 1.000 Credit hours

Prerequisites

None.

When Offered:

Every Semester

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